Design and Optimisation of an Automotive Rear Window Defroster

MULTIPHYSICS MODELLING USING COMSOL

ME46095

Authors:

Irian ()
Muhammad Sebtain (4532589)

April 14, 2026

Delft University of Technology

Chapter 1

Model Definition

1.1 Introduction

Rear window condensation and frost are a common problem in automotive vehicles, especially during the colder months when the glass surface temperature drops below the dew point of surrounding air [1]. When this happen, the moisture from cabin air will condense on the inner surface of the glass, this significantly reduces the driver's rear visibility and create a safety hazard [2]. To address this issue, most of the modern vehicles are equipped with electrically heated rear window defrosters which uses thin resistive traces that are embedded on the glass to raise it's surface temperature above the dew point.

1.1.1 Problem Statement

The aim of this study is to design and also optimise a resistive rear window defroster system for standard automotive application, using finite element multiphysics modelling in COMSOL Multiphysics 6.2. More specifically, the study seek to answer the following questions:

1. What is the optimal number of heating traces and the operating voltage that is needed to make sure the entire glass surface temperature exceed the dew point?
2. Which trace material out of the available candidates (sourced from CES EduPack database [3]) provides the best balance between thermal performance and structural integrity?
3. How long does it take for the defroster to fully clear the window from a initial frosted condition, and can this be improved by using non-uniform trace spacing?
4. Is the final design robust enough to perform adequately across a range of realistic weather condition?

The defroster must raise the entire glass surface temperature above the dew point to eliminates condensation and frost at the same time it should remaining within safe thermal and mechanical stress limits. The design was developed iteratively through a series of simulations with increasing complexity. We started from a baseline model and then we refining the configuration through parametric sweeps, material selection, stress analysis, trace spacing optimisation, and at the end we also performed a weather study for robustness testing.

1.2 Problem Description

Rear window defrosters work by passing an electric current through thin conductive traces that are deposited on the inner surface of the glass [4]. The Joule heating that is produced in the traces conducts into the glass, which raises it's temperature above the dew point [5]. The main design challenge here is achieving sufficiently uniform heating across the entire window, while using a minimum number of traces at a voltage compatible with the standard $12\,\mathrm{V}$ automotive electrical system [6].
The design must satisfies three main criteria:

1. **Thermal:** The minimum surface temperature of glass must exceeds the dew point temperature ($T_{\text{dew}} = 283.15\,\mathrm{K}$, at $10\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$) [1].
2. **Structural:** The thermal stresses from differential expansion between the trace material and glass must remains below material yield strengths [4].
3. **Transient:** The window should be defrosted within a reasonable time (target: $\leq 15\,\mathrm{min}$) [7].

1.3 Geometry

The model is represented by a two-dimensional flat rear window, which is a common approach used in literature for this type of problem [4, 5]. The geometry consists of three components:

- A rectangular glass pane of dimensions $L_{\text{glass}} \times H_{\text{glass}} = 1.5\,\text{m} \times 0.8\,\text{m}$
- Horizontal conductive heating traces spanning the full width of the glass. These are created using a linear array
- Two vertical bus bars (left and right edges) connecting all traces to the power supply

The number of traces (n_{traces}) is a key design variable, swept from 8 to 22 in the parametric studies. The traces are uniformly spaced across the glass height. Figure 1.1 shows the COMSOL geometry for the baseline configuration.

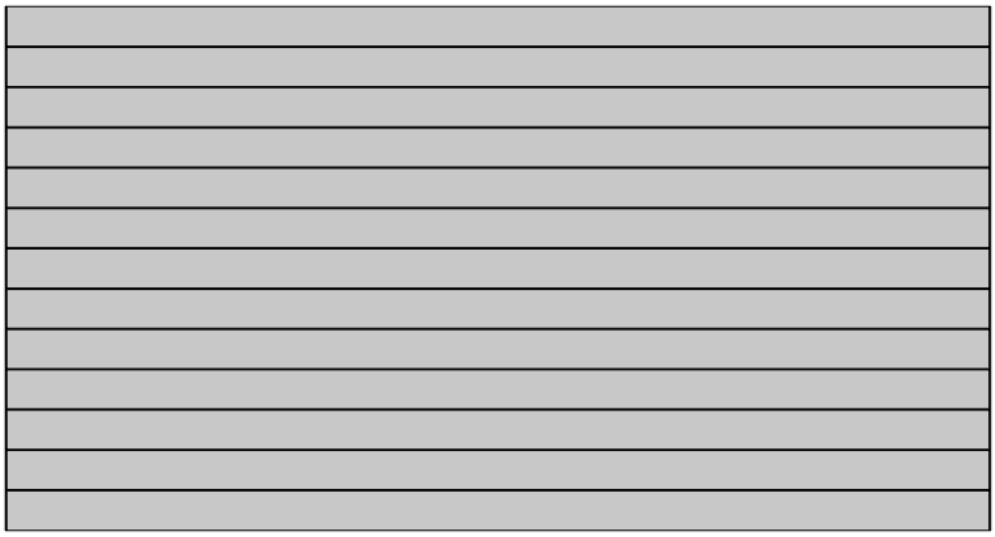


Figure 1.1: Two-dimensional geometry of the rear window defroster model showing the glass pane, horizontal heating traces, and vertical bus bars. Configuration shown: $n_{\text{traces}} = 12$.

The geometric parameters used in COMSOL are listed in Table 1.1.

Table 1.1: Geometric parameters of the rear window defroster model.

Parameter	Symbol	Value	Description
Glass length	L_{glass}	$1.5\,\text{m}$	Width of the window
Glass height	H_{glass}	$0.8\,\text{m}$	Height of the window
Glass thickness	t_{glass}	$5\,\text{mm}$	Out-of-plane thickness
Trace width	w_{trace}	$1.7\,\text{mm}$	Width of each heating trace
Trace thickness	t_{trace}	$0.11\,\text{mm}$	Thickness of each trace
Number of traces	n_{traces}	8–22 (swept)	Design variable

Since the model is two-dimensional with out-of-plane thickness, an effective 2D electrical conductivity is used for the traces:

$$\sigma_{\text{eff}} = \sigma_{\text{trace}} \cdot \frac{t_{\text{trace}}}{t_{\text{glass}}} \tag{1.1}$$

This accounts for the fact that the thin conductive traces occupy only a fraction of the out-of-plane glass thickness. The trace dimensions used here is consistent with typical screen-printed defroster traces reported in the literature [7].

1.4 Materials

The window glass is modelled as tempered soda-lime glass using COMSOL's built-in material library. The key properties are listed in Table 1.2.

Table 1.2: Material properties of tempered soda-lime glass.

Property	Value	Source
Thermal conductivity (k)	$1.4\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$	COMSOL library
Density (ρ)	$2500\,\mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}}$	COMSOL library
Heat capacity (C_p)	$750\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$	COMSOL library
Fracture strength	$120\,\mathrm{MPa}$	Literature

Four candidate trace materials were evaluated, with properties sourced from the CES EduPack database [3]. The full property set is given in Table 1.3.

Table 1.3: Trace material properties from CES EduPack [3]. σ: electrical conductivity, α: coefficient of thermal expansion, E: Young's modulus, ν: Poisson's ratio.

Material	σ ($\mathrm{S\,m^{-1}}$)	α ($\mathrm{K^{-1}}$)	E (GPa)	ν	Yield (MPa)
Pd–Ag alloy	2.3×10^6	15×10^{-6}	102.5	0.38	410
Silver (comm. purity)	5.75×10^7	19.7×10^{-6}	71	0.39	190
Gold (soft annealed)	4.2×10^7	14×10^{-6}	78.5	0.42	20
Nichrome V	9.3×10^5	13×10^{-6}	212.5	0.29	365

1.5 Boundary Conditions

The boundary conditions represents a cold winter morning scenario, where the exterior of the glass is expose to ambient air and the interior is facing the vehicle cabin. The values are listed in Table 1.4.

Table 1.4: Boundary conditions and environmental parameters.

Parameter	Symbol	Value	Description
Ambient temperature	T_{amb}	$275.15\,\mathrm{K}$ ($2\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$)	Exterior air
Cabin temperature	T_{cabin}	$293.15\,\mathrm{K}$ ($20\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$)	Interior cabin air
Initial temperature	T_{init}	$278.15\,\mathrm{K}$ ($5\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$)	Frosted window (transient)
Dew point temperature	T_{dew}	$283.15\,\mathrm{K}$ ($10\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$)	Target minimum temperature
External heat transfer coeff.	h_{ext}	$15\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$	Exterior convection
Internal heat transfer coeff.	h_{int}	$7\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$	Interior convection
Applied voltage	V_{in}	10–$14.5\,\mathrm{V}$ (swept)	Automotive 12V system range

Electrical. A electric potential V_{in} is applied on the left bus bar, and ground ($V = 0$) on the right bus bar. The electric current physics are defined only on the trace and bus bar domains (not the glass, which is electrically insulating).
Thermal. Since the model is 2D with out-of-plane thickness, heat loses to the exterior and interior are modelled using a volumetric heat source which accounts for convection on both sides of the glass:

$$Q_{\text{conv}} = \frac{h_{\text{ext}}(T_{\text{amb}} - T) + h_{\text{int}}(T_{\text{cabin}} - T)}{t_{\text{glass}}} \tag{1.2}$$

This expression replace the out-of-plane heat flux boundary condition, which caused spatial frame conflicts in COMSOL 6.2 when it is coupled with solid mechanics.
Mechanical. For the stress analysis (Sim 2c), fixed constraints are applied on the left and right outer edges of the glass, representing the car body frame which holds the window. This is a conservative simplification, in reality a rubber seal provides some compliance.

1.6 Physics Coupling and Governing Equations

The model involve three coupled physics interfaces: Electric Currents (ec), Heat Transfer in Solids (ht), and Solid Mechanics (solid). Each of these physics captures a different aspect of the defroster behaviour, and they are coupled together through multiphysics nodes in COMSOL. The coupling between them is illustrated in Figure 1.2.
The first physics is **Electric Currents**, which solves for the electric potential distribution across the conductive traces and bus bars. When a voltage is applied across the bus bars, current will flows through the traces and this generates resistive heating. This physics is only active on the trace and bus bar domains since the glass itself is electrically insulating. The second physics is **Heat Transfer in Solids**, which computes the temperature field across the entire glass and trace domains. It recieves the Joule heating from Electric Currents as a volumetric heat source through the *Electromagnetic Heating* multiphysics coupling. This is what actually heats up the glass. The third physics is **Solid Mechanics**, which calculate the mechanical stresses and deformations that arises from the temperature differences in the model. It is coupled to Heat Transfer through the *Thermal Expansion* multiphysics node, which converts temperature changes into thermal strains. This coupling is important because the trace materials and the glass has different coefficients of thermal expansion, so when they heat up together they will expand by different amounts which creates stress at the interface.

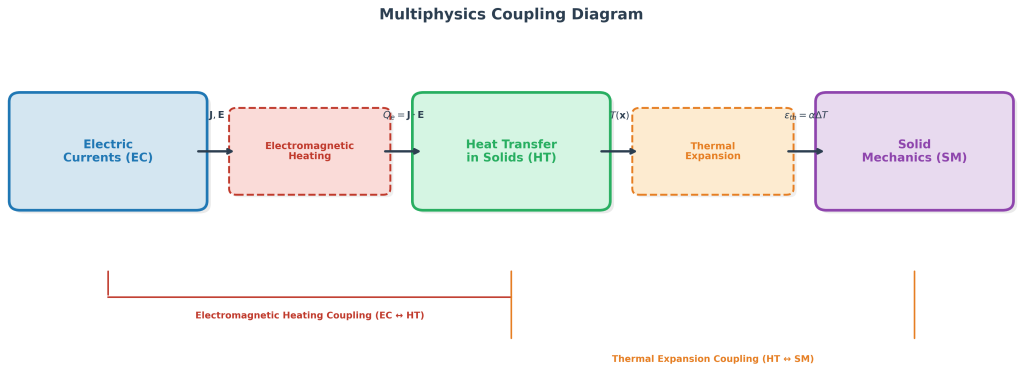


Figure 1.2: Physics coupling in the multiphysics model. Joule heating from Electric Currents drives Heat Transfer, which in turn drives thermal expansion in Solid Mechanics.

The governing equations for each physics are given below.
Electric Currents. The electric field in the conductive traces are governed by current conservation:

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{J} = 0 \tag{1.3}$$

where $\mathbf{J} = \sigma_{\text{eff}}\mathbf{E}$ is the current density and $\mathbf{E} = -\nabla V$ is the electric field.
Heat Transfer in Solids. The heat equation in the glass domain are:

$$\rho C_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} = \nabla \cdot (k \nabla T) + Q_e + Q_{\text{conv}} \tag{1.4}$$

where $Q_e = \mathbf{J} \cdot \mathbf{E}$ is the resistive (Joule) heating that comes from the Electromagnetic Heating multiphysics coupling, and Q_{conv} is the convective heat source from Equation (1.2).
For stationary studies the left-hand side is zero so the equation reduce to:

$$\nabla \cdot (k \nabla T) + Q_e + Q_{\text{conv}} = 0 \tag{1.5}$$

Solid Mechanics. The mechanical equilibrium are described by:

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{S} + \mathbf{F}_v = 0 \tag{1.6}$$

where $\mathbf{S}$ is the Cauchy stress tensor. Thermal expansion introduce an initial strain:

$$\varepsilon_{\text{th}} = \alpha(T - T_{\text{ref}})\mathbf{I} \tag{1.7}$$

with a reference temperature of $T_{\text{ref}} = T_{\text{amb}} = 275.15\,\text{K}$.

Chapter 2

Model Implementation in COMSOL

The design was developed iteratively through five simulations of increasing complexity. Each simulation builds on the previous one, progressively refining the design from a baseline model to a fully optimised transient solution. Table 2.1 summarises all simulations.

Table 2.1: Overview of simulations performed.

Simulation	Study Type	Sweep Parameters	Objective
Sim 1	Stationary	None (baseline)	Verify model physics
Sim 2	Stationary	V_{in}, n_{traces}	Identify viable operating range
Sim 2b	Stationary	Material, n_{traces}, V_{in}	Material optimisation
Sim 2c	Stationary (sequential)	Material, n_{traces}	Stress analysis
Sim 3	Time dependent	Material, n_{traces}, V_{in}	Defrost time
Sim 4	Time dependent	Zone layout (n_{top}, n_{mid}, n_{bot})	Zoned trace spacing
Sim 5	Time dependent	Chebyshev exponent p	Non-uniform spacing optimisation
Sim 6	Time dependent	Weather scenario	Robustness across climate conditions

2.1 Simulation 1 — Baseline Stationary Model

The first simulation establishes the baseline model with the default configuration: 12 traces of silver paste ($\sigma = 2\times10^6\,\mathrm{S\,m^{-1}}$) at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$. A stationary study couples Electric Currents and Heat Transfer via Electromagnetic Heating.
The purpose of Sim 1 is to verify that:

- The voltage gradient across the traces is correct (12 V at the left bus bar, 0 V at the right)
- The temperature distribution is physically realistic (in the range 270–320 K)
- The cold spots are located at the expected positions (top and bottom edges farthest from traces)

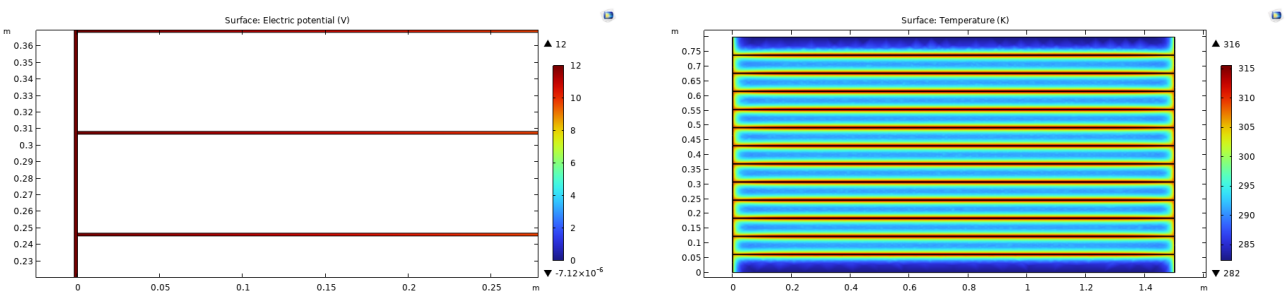


Figure 2.1: Sim 1 baseline results at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$, $n_{\text{traces}} = 12$, silver paste. (a) Electric potential distribution on the traces and bus bars. (b) Temperature distribution across the glass surface.

The baseline results show a surface-average temperature of $297.13\,\mathrm{K}$ (above the dew point) but a surface-minimum temperature of $282.12\,\mathrm{K}$ (below the dew point). The cold spots are at the top and bottom edges of the glass where trace coverage does not extend. This motivates the parametric sweeps in the following simulations.

2.2 Simulation 2 — Voltage and Trace Count Sweeps

Sim 2 investigates the sensitivity of the minimum glass temperature to the applied voltage and number of traces, independently and in combination.
A parametric sweep of V_{in} from $8\,\text{V}$ to $16\,\text{V}$ (9 values) is performed at $n_{\text{traces}} = 12$. Even at $16\,\text{V}$, the minimum temperature ($283.09\,\text{K}$) barely reaches the dew point, indicating that voltage alone cannot solve the problem with 12 traces.
A parametric sweep of n_{traces} from 8 to 22 is performed at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$. Results are shown in Figure 2.2.

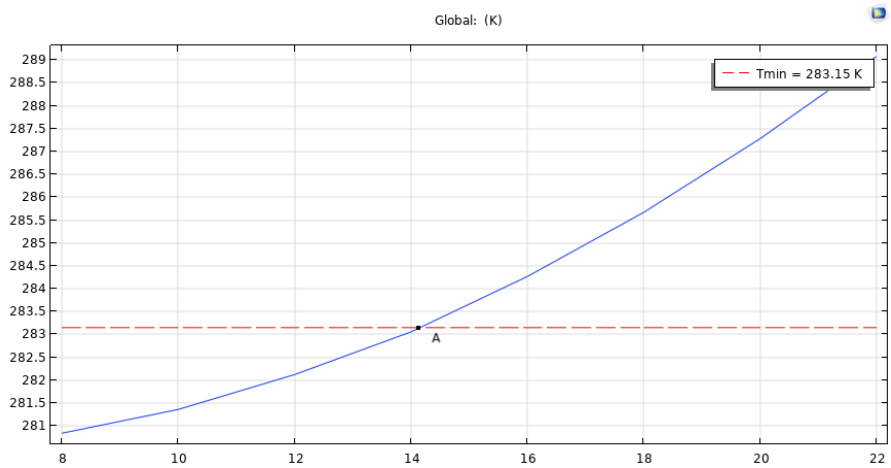


Figure 2.2: Minimum glass surface temperature as a function of the number of traces at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$. The horizontal dashed line indicates the dew point temperature ($283.15\,\text{K}$).

A full factorial sweep over $n_{\text{traces}} \in \{8, 10, 12, 14, 16, 18, 20, 22\}$ and $V_{\text{in}} \in \{8, 10, 12, 14, 16\}$ V produces 35 stationary solutions. Results are shown in Table 2.2.

Table 2.2: Minimum surface temperature T_{min} (K) for the combined voltage–trace count sweep (silver paste, $\sigma = 2 \times 10^6\,\text{S}\,\text{m}^{-1}$). Values $\geq 283.15\,\text{K}$ are shown in **bold**.

n_{traces}	$8\,\text{V}$	$10\,\text{V}$	$12\,\text{V}$	$14\,\text{V}$	$16\,\text{V}$
8	280.86	280.85	280.84	280.83	280.81
10	281.09	281.21	281.36	281.54	281.74
12	281.43	281.74	282.12	282.57	**283.09**
14	281.85	282.39	**283.06**	**283.84**	**284.75**
16	282.38	**283.23**	**284.27**	**285.49**	**286.91**
18	**283.01**	**284.21**	**285.67**	**287.40**	**289.40**
20	**283.72**	**285.33**	**287.28**	**289.60**	**292.27**
22	**284.52**	**286.57**	**289.08**	**292.04**	**295.46**

The key conclusion is that **increasing the number of traces is more effective than increasing voltage**. The cheapest solution above the dew point is 16 traces at $10\,\text{V}$ ($283.23\,\text{K}$).

2.3 Simulation 2b — Material Optimisation

Sim 2b extend the parametric sweep to includes four candidate trace materials from the CES EduPack database [3]. The sweep is covering $4 \times 8 \times 4 = 128$ combinations (4 materials, 8 trace counts and 4 voltages).
The voltages used reflects the realistic automotive range: $10\,\text{V}$ (battery low), $12\,\text{V}$ (nominal), $13.5\,\text{V}$ (engine is running), and $14.5\,\text{V}$ (maximum alternator output).
The minimum number of traces which is needed to reach the dew point for each material and voltage are shown in Table 2.3.

Table 2.3: Minimum number of traces to reach $T_{\text{min}} \geq 283.15\,\text{K}$ for each material and voltage.

Material	$10\,\text{V}$	$12\,\text{V}$	$13.5\,\text{V}$	$14.5\,\text{V}$
Pd–Ag alloy	16	14	14	14
Nichrome V	22	18	18	16
Silver (comm. purity)	*Overheats — not viable*			
Gold (soft annealed)	*Overheats — not viable*			

For Pd–Ag alloy, the dew point was been reached at as few as 14 traces at $12\,\text{V}$ ($283.38\,\text{K}$), going all the way up to $294.65\,\text{K}$ at 22 traces and $14.5\,\text{V}$, which gives a quite wide viable operating range. Nichrome V on the other hand need more traces to achieves the same result — the dew point was first reach at 16 traces and $14.5\,\text{V}$ ($283.18\,\text{K}$), and the maximum T_{min} that was recorded across the whole sweep is only $286.45\,\text{K}$ at 22 traces and $14.5\,\text{V}$. The full trends for both of the materials can be seen in Figure 2.3.

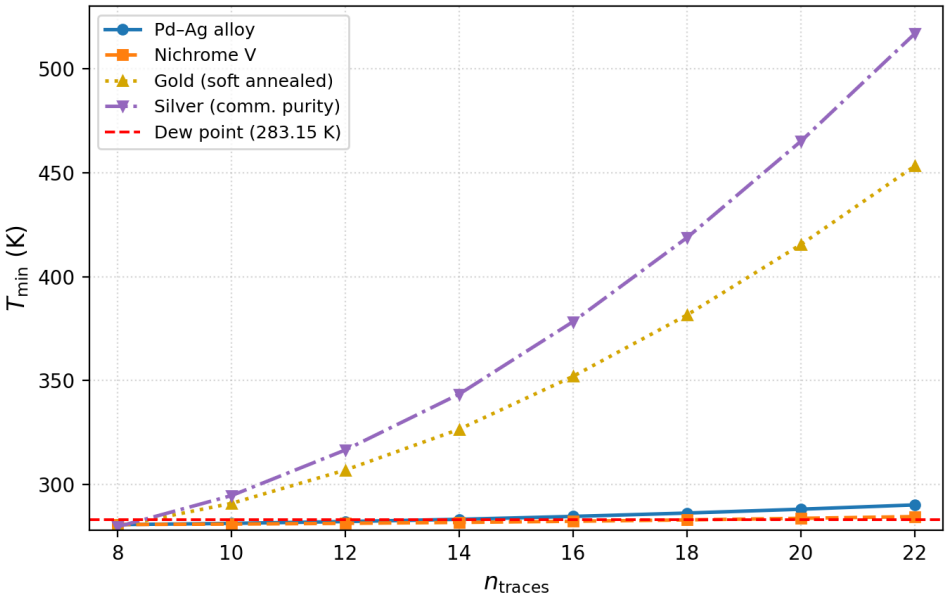


Figure 2.3: Comparison of minimum surface temperature vs. number of traces for all four EduPack materials at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$. Silver and Gold exceed safe temperatures at $n_{\text{traces}} \geq 10$ and are not viable.

- **Silver (commercial purity) and Gold (soft annealed) are not viable** — their bulk conductivity ($> 10^7$ S/m) are too high for the screen-printed geometry, causing extreme overheating (Silver reach $625\,\text{K}$ at 22 traces, $14.5\,\text{V}$).
- **Pd–Ag alloy is the best EduPack material** — it reaches the dew point at 14 traces ($12\,\text{V}$+). The temperatures remains in a safe range.
- **Nichrome V is viable but requires more traces** (18–22 depending on the voltage).

2.4 Simulation 2c — Stress Analysis

Sim 2c evaluate the thermal stresses for the two shortlisted materials (Pd–Ag alloy and Nichrome V). Silver and Gold was excluded from this analysis as both materials overheats severely in Sim 2b, making them not viable candidate for the defroster design. Since stress analysis are only relevant for materials that actually meets the thermal criteria, there is no point to included them here.
The voltage range were also narrowed down to $12\,\text{V}$ and $14.5\,\text{V}$ only. The $12\,\text{V}$ represents the nominal battery voltage which is the primary operating condition, and $14.5\,\text{V}$ represents the maximum alternator output which is the most worst-case scenario in terms of Joule heating and therefore thermal stress. The intermediate voltages of $10\,\text{V}$ and $13.5\,\text{V}$ was not included as they do not adds additional informations beyond what these two extreme cases already captures.
For the trace count, only configurations from $n_{\text{traces}} = 14$ to $n_{\text{traces}} = 22$ was selected. This is because Sim 2b showed that below 14 traces, neither material is able to reaches the dew point at any of the tested voltages, so performing a stress analysis on these configurations would of been pointless.

Solid Mechanics and Thermal Expansion are re-enabled, and a sequential solve were used:

- **Step 1:** Electric Currents + Heat Transfer (stationary)
- **Step 2:** Solid Mechanics with Thermal Expansion (stationary, using Step 1 temperatures)

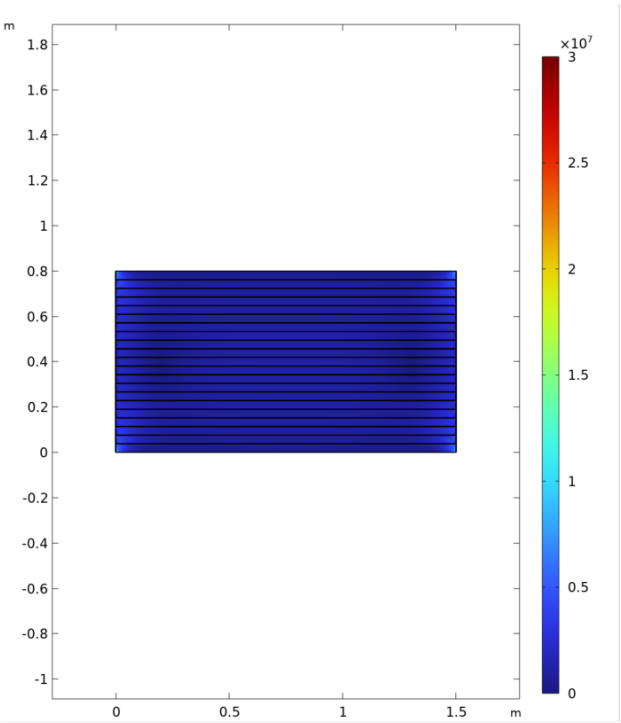
This sequential approach avoid the spatial frame conflict ("dvol_spatial undefined") which is encountered when solving all the physics simultaneously in COMSOL 6.2.

Table 2.4: Von Mises stress results for Pd–Ag alloy (yield strength = $410\,\mathrm{MPa}$). Safety factor = yield / max stress.

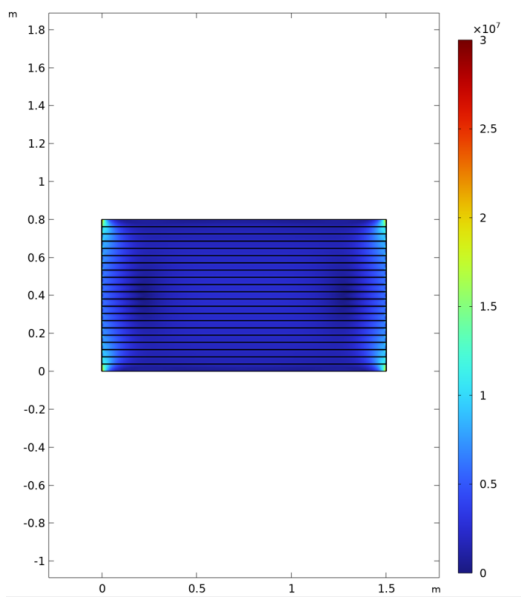
n_{traces}	**Max stress at** $12\,\mathrm{V}$ **(MPa)**	**SF at** $12\,\mathrm{V}$	**Max stress at** $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$ **(MPa)**	**SF at** $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$
14	120.1	3.42×	167.7	2.44×
16	126.5	3.24×	176.9	2.32×
18	133.4	3.07×	187.0	2.19×
20	141.2	2.90×	198.4	2.07×
22	150.9	2.72×	212.6	1.93×

Table 2.5: Von Mises stress results for Nichrome V (yield strength = $365\,\mathrm{MPa}$). Safety factor = yield / max stress.

n_{traces}	**Max stress at** $12\,\mathrm{V}$ **(MPa)**	**SF at** $12\,\mathrm{V}$	**Max stress at** $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$ **(MPa)**	**SF at** $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$
14	93.9	3.89×	124.9	2.92×
16	98.2	3.72×	131.0	2.79×
18	102.6	3.56×	137.6	2.65×
20	106.7	3.42×	143.7	2.54×
22	111.2	3.28×	150.2	2.43×



(a) Nichrome V (max stress = $106.7\,\mathrm{MPa}$, SF = 3.42×)



(b) Pd–Ag alloy (max stress = $141.2\,\mathrm{MPa}$, SF = 2.90×)

Figure 2.4: Von Mises stress distribution (N/m^2) at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$, $n_{\text{traces}} = 20$ for both trace materials. The colour scale ranges from 0 to 3×10^7 N/m^2 and the red contour lines shows stress levels. Peak stresses concentrate at trace endpoints near the fixed edges, the glass bulk stress remain very low throughout.

Both materials passes the stress constraint across all configurations tested. At the recommended operating voltage of $12\,\mathrm{V}$, safety factors ranges from 2.72$\times$ to 3.42$\times$ for Pd–Ag alloy and from 3.28$\times$ to 3.89$\times$ for Nichrome V. At the maximum voltage of $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$, the safety factors are lower but still remains above 1.9$\times$ for all configurations.
The thermal stresses arises because the conductive traces is bonded directly onto the glass surface, and the trace materials has a higher coefficient of thermal expansion compared to the glass (for example, Pd–Ag has $\alpha = 15 \times 10^{-6}\,\mathrm{K}^{-1}$ compared to $\approx 9 \times 10^{-6}\,\mathrm{K}^{-1}$ for soda-lime glass). When the traces heat up due to Joule heating, they tries to expand more than the glass underneath it, but since they are attached to the glass this mismatch in expansion create stresses at the interface between the trace and glass. The fixed edge constraints on left and right boundaries further restrict the glass from deforming freely, which amplify the stress near the trace endpoints at the edges. This is why peak von Mises stresses concentrates at the trace endpoints near the fixed boundary — it is a conservative artifact of the fully fixed edge condition (in reality a rubber seal would provide some compliance). The glass bulk stress away from the traces remains very low, well below the $120\,\mathrm{MPa}$ fracture strength of tempered glass [4].

2.5 Simulation 3 — Transient Defrost Study

Sim 3 evaluates how long each configuration take to defrost the window starting from the initial frosted condition ($T_{\text{init}} = 278.15\,\mathrm{K}$) until the point where $T_{\text{min}} \geq T_{\text{dew}}$.
A time-dependent study were used with output times from 0 to $3600\,\mathrm{s}$ in $60\,\mathrm{s}$ increments. The Electric Currents equation was set to stationary form since the electric field equilibrate in microseconds compared to the thermal time scale which is in minutes. Solid Mechanics was disabled for computational efficiency since we do not need the stress results for this simulation.
The sweep cover: 2 materials $\times$ 5 trace counts (14, 16, 18, 20, 22) $\times$ 2 voltages (12, $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$) = 20 runs. The mesh were also refined to Fine (189,192 domain elements) for better accuracy.
The overall defrost-time comparison for both materials is shown in Figure 2.5, while the detailed transient response for Pd–Ag alloy at $12\,\mathrm{V}$ is shown in Figure 2.6.

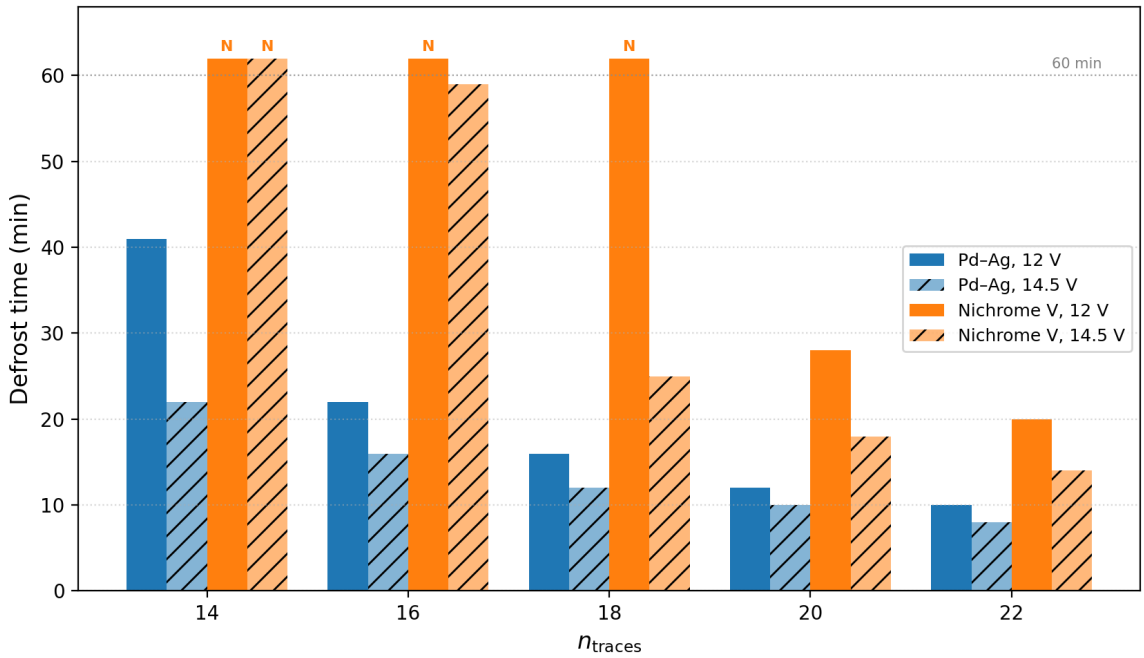


Figure 2.5: Defrost time comparison between Pd–Ag alloy and Nichrome V at $12\,\mathrm{V}$ and $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$. “N” indicates the configuration never reaches the dew point within $60\,\mathrm{min}$.

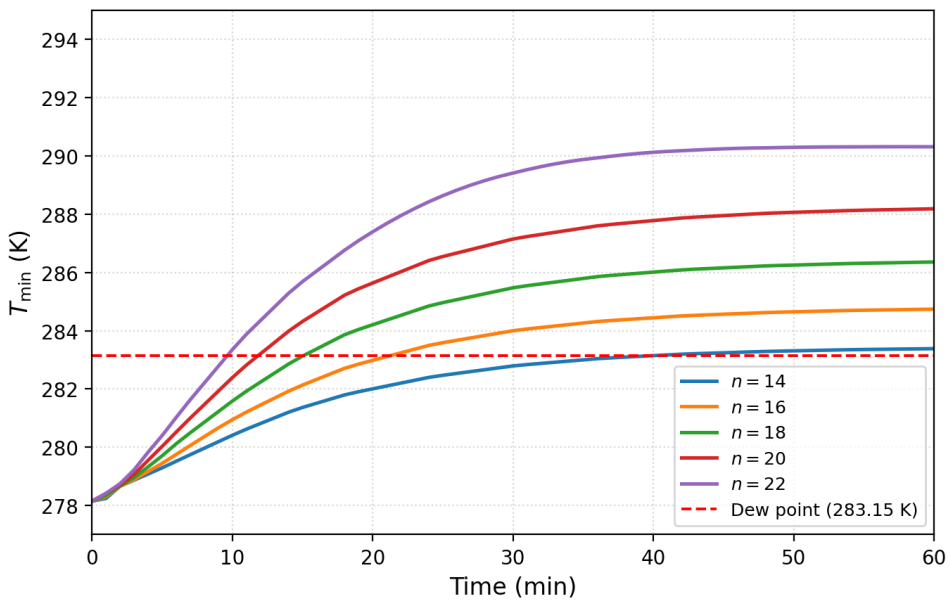


Figure 2.6: Transient evolution of minimum surface temperature for Pd–Ag alloy at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$ for different numbers of traces. The horizontal dashed line indicates the dew point.

Pd–Ag alloy defrosts faster than Nichrome V across the full sweep. At $12\,\text{V}$, Pd–Ag reaches the dew point with as few as 14 traces, although slowly ($41\,\text{min}$), and improves to $12\,\text{min}$ at 20 traces and $10\,\text{min}$ at 22 traces. Nichrome V performs noticeably worse: it does not defrost at all below 20 traces at $12\,\text{V}$, and even at $14.5\,\text{V}$ it only reaches the dew point in $59\,\text{min}$ for 16 traces. This confirms that Pd–Ag alloy provides the more practical operating window for battery-level voltage.
Based on these results, **Pd–Ag alloy with $n_{\text{traces}} = 20$ at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$ were selected as the recommended design**. The key reason for this are:

- **Battery-only operation:** A nominal automotive 12 V system operate directly from the battery without the engine running [6]. This is critical for a rear defroster, which must function during a cold start before the engine—and therefore the alternator—are active. Voltages of $13.5\,\text{V}$ and $14.5\,\text{V}$ are only available when the alternator is charging, which require the engine to be running.
- **Acceptable defrost time:** At $12\,\text{V}$, 20 traces defrosts the window in $12\,\text{min}$ — which is well within a practical warm-up period.
- **Adequate thermal margin:** The steady-state $T_{\text{min}} = 288.2\,\text{K}$ are $5.05\,\text{K}$ above the dew point, which provide a comfortable margin against condensation re-forming.
- **Diminishing returns at 22 traces:** If you increase to 22 traces it only reduce defrost time by 2 minutes (10 vs. 12 min at $12\,\text{V}$) at the cost of higher material use and also increased trace density.

An alternative configuration of 22 traces at $14.5\,\text{V}$ can achieves defrost in $8\,\text{min}$ but it require the engine to be running and therefore it is only suitable as a secondary high-performance mode.

2.6 Simulation 4 — Trace Pattern Optimisation

After establishing the optimal material (Pd–Ag alloy) and operating conditions in the previous simulations, Sim 4 investigates the effect of trace layout on the temperature uniformity across the glass surface. The baseline simulations revealed that cold spots form at the top and bottom edges of the glass, farthest from any heating trace. A natural mitigation strategy is to concentrate more traces near these edges.
The glass is divided into three horizontal zones with independent trace densities:

- **Top zone:** $H_{\text{top}} = 200\,\text{mm}$, $n_{\text{top}} = 6$ traces
- **Middle zone:** $H_{\text{mid}} = 400\,\text{mm}$, $n_{\text{mid}} = 8$ traces
- **Bottom zone:** $H_{\text{bot}} = 200\,\text{mm}$, $n_{\text{bot}} = 6$ traces

This gives a total of 20 traces (same as the recommended uniform design) but with denser spacing in the edge zones. The edge gap is $28.6\,\mathrm{mm}$ (vs. $38.1\,\mathrm{mm}$ uniform), and the centre gap is $44.4\,\mathrm{mm}$.
Zone parameters were added to Global Definitions and each zone was created as a separate Rectangle + Array in the geometry, with spacing $H_{\text{zone}}/(n_{\text{zone}}+1)$. The old uniform-spacing geometry (Array 1 + Rectangle 2) was disabled.

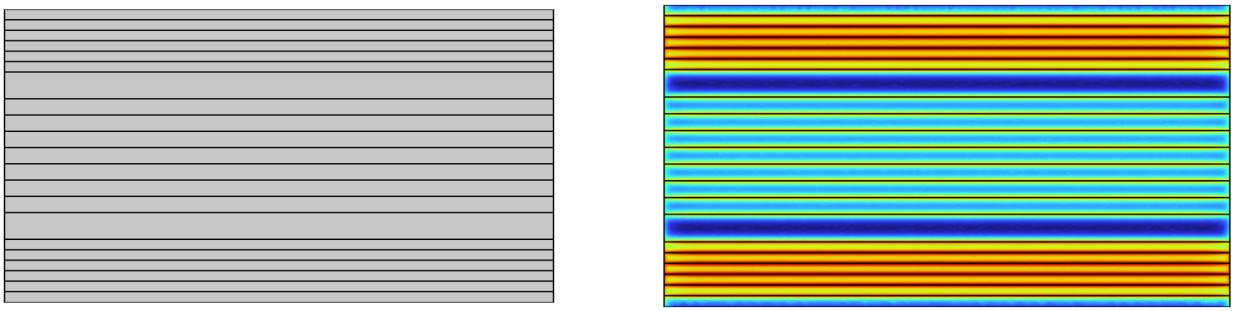


Figure 2.7: Zoned trace layout (Approach A). (a) Geometry with 6/8/6 distribution across top/middle/bottom zones. (b) Steady-state temperature distribution showing reduced cold spots at the edges.

The study was changed from stationary to time dependent with output range `range(0,60,3600)`, i.e. every $60\,\mathrm{s}$ for $60\,\mathrm{min}$. The Electric Currents equation form was set to Stationary (as in Sim 3) since the electric field equilibrates instantaneously compared to the thermal time scale. The initial temperature was set to $T_{\text{init}} = 278.15\,\mathrm{K}$.
The zoned approach was not pursued further because the continuous Chebyshev spacing (Sim 5) proved far more effective, as discussed in Section 2.7.

2.7 Simulation 5 — Chebyshev Trace Spacing Optimisation

While the zoned approach (Sim 4) provides a discrete improvement, a mathematically elegant alternative is to use a continuous spacing function that naturally clusters traces near the edges. Chebyshev node spacing, derived from the roots of Chebyshev polynomials, is well known in numerical analysis for minimising interpolation error by placing points near interval boundaries. This property is analogous to the defroster design goal of concentrating heating where it is most needed.

2.7.1 Spacing Formula and Implementation

The vertical position y_i of the i-th trace ($i = 1, \ldots, 20$) is given by:

$$y_i = \frac{H_{\text{glass}}}{2}\left(1 - \text{sign}\left(\cos\frac{i\pi}{21}\right)\left|\cos\frac{i\pi}{21}\right|^p\right) \tag{2.1}$$

where p is a clustering exponent that controls how aggressively the traces are pushed toward the edges:

- $p < 1$: More uniform than standard Chebyshev (less edge clustering)
- $p = 1$: Standard Chebyshev distribution
- $p > 1$: More aggressive edge clustering

The $\text{sign}(\cdot)|\cdot|^p$ formulation preserves the symmetry of the cosine distribution for all values of p, including non-integer exponents.
Twenty individual rectangles were created in the geometry, each with a unique y-position computed from Equation (2.1). The exponent p was defined as a global parameter, enabling a parametric sweep. All other model settings (material: Pd–Ag alloy, σ_{eff} correction, time-dependent study, boundary conditions) were identical to Sim 4.

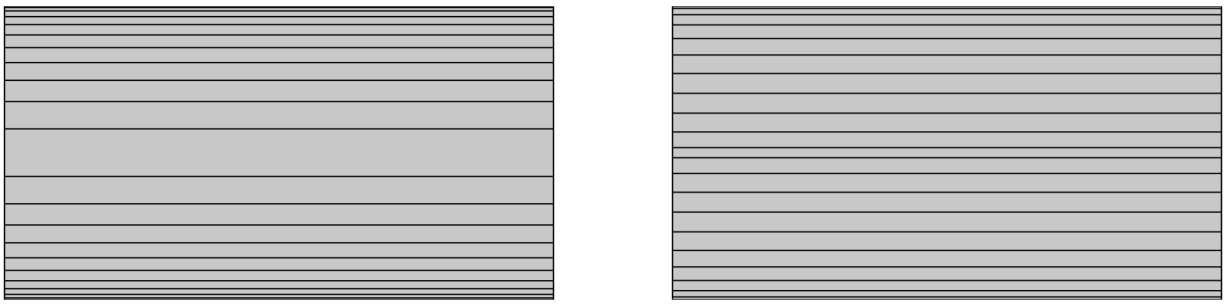


Figure 2.8: Chebyshev trace spacing for (a) $p = 0.7$ (near-uniform) and (b) $p = 1.3$ (optimal). Edge gaps decrease significantly with increasing p while centre gaps widen.

2.7.2 Results and Optimum

Three values of p were tested first to establish the feasibility of the approach:

- $p = 1.0$ (standard Chebyshev): **defrost in** $7\,\mathrm{min}$, steady-state $T_{\text{min}} = 292.6\,\mathrm{K}$
- $p = 0.85$: **never reaches dew point** — steady-state $T_{\text{min}} = 282.06\,\mathrm{K}$
- $p = 0.7$: **never reaches dew point** — steady-state $T_{\text{min}} = 282.06\,\mathrm{K}$

The $p = 1.0$ result is dramatic: defrost time is reduced from $12\,\mathrm{min}$ (uniform) to $7\,\mathrm{min}$ — a 42% improvement with exactly the same number of traces, same material, and same voltage. However, reducing p below 1.0 removes too much edge clustering and the cold spots return.
To find the optimal exponent, a parametric sweep was performed over $p \in \{0.7, 0.8, 0.9, 0.95, 1.0, 1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 1.5, 1.6, 1.7, 1$
All runs use 20 traces of Pd–Ag alloy at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$. The trace y-positions were expressed parametrically in terms of p, so COMSOL automatically updates the geometry for each sweep value.
The results are presented in Table 2.6 and plotted in Figure 2.9.

Table 2.6: Chebyshev exponent sweep results (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$). $T_{360\text{s}}$: minimum temperature at $t = 6\,\mathrm{min}$.

p	T_{min} at $t = 360\,\mathrm{s}$ (K)	**Defrost time**	**Steady-state** T_{min} (K)
0.70	279.53	Never	282.1
0.80	279.72	23 min	284.0
0.90	280.44	12 min	287.5
1.00	282.23	8 min	292.6
1.10	282.97	7 min	294.5
1.20	283.16	6 min	294.9
1.30	**283.20**	**6 min**	**295.0**
1.40	283.09	6 min	294.8
1.50	282.97	7 min	294.5
1.60	282.91	7 min	294.4
1.70	282.74	7 min	293.9
1.80	282.56	7 min	293.4
1.90	282.40	7 min	293.1
2.00	282.28	7 min	292.8
3.00	281.17	9 min	289.9

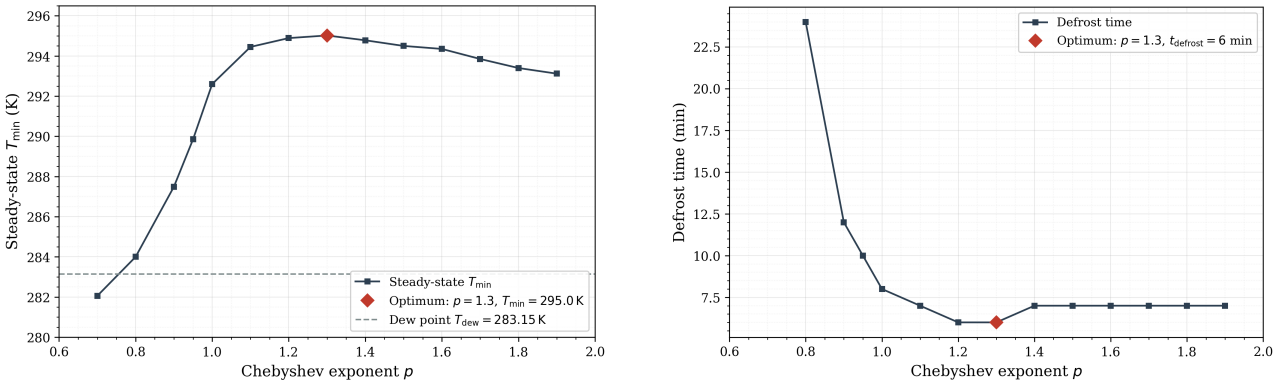


Figure 2.9: Effect of the Chebyshev exponent p on (a) steady-state minimum temperature and (b) defrost time. The optimum is $p = 1.3$, achieving the highest T_{min} and fastest defrost.

The optimum is clearly at $p = 1.3$: it achieves the highest minimum temperature at the 6-minute mark ($283.20\,\text{K}$) and the highest steady-state T_{min} ($295.0\,\text{K}$). The physical interpretation is:

- $p < 1.0$**:** Insufficient edge clustering. The edges remain cold, and the centre is over-heated with closely spaced traces — reproducing the original problem.
- $p = 1.0$**–**1.3**:** Increasing p progressively moves more traces to the edges, heating the cold spots more effectively. The centre gap widens but the glass thermal conductivity is sufficient to bridge it.
- $p > 1.3$**:** Over-clustering at edges. The centre becomes a cold spot because the traces are too far apart. At $p = 2.0$ the cosine-squared creates three clusters (two edges plus centre), and at $p = 3.0$ the clustering is too sharp for the window height.

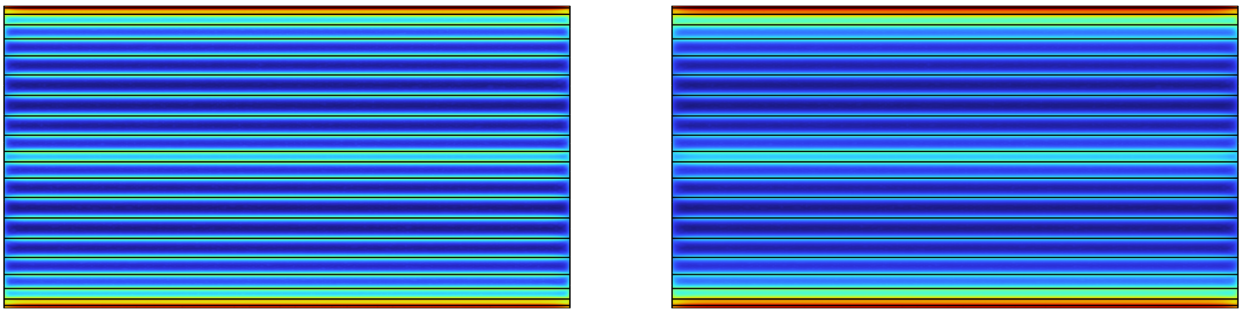


Figure 2.10: Temperature distribution for Chebyshev spacing $p = 1.3$ (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $12\,\text{V}$). (a) At $t = 6\,\text{min}$ (defrost moment): $T_{\text{min}} = 283.20\,\text{K}$. (b) Steady state: $T_{\text{min}} = 295.0\,\text{K}$.

2.7.3 Practical Considerations

An important practical constraint for rear window trace patterns is driver visibility. Per the SAE J216 standard, obscuration of the rear vision area should not exceed 5% in the primary zone [2]. For 20 traces with $w_{\text{trace}} = 1.7\,\text{mm}$:

$$\text{Obscuration} = \frac{n_{\text{traces}} \times w_{\text{trace}}}{H_{\text{glass}}} = \frac{20 \times 1.7}{800} = 4.25\% \tag{2.2}$$

This is well within the 5% limit regardless of the spacing pattern, since the total trace area is unchanged. The Chebyshev spacing only redistributes the same number of traces, so visibility is not affected.
Adding vertical traces between the horizontal ones was considered to create a grid pattern. However, analysis showed this would be ineffective: since all parallel horizontal traces are at the same voltage at any given x-position, vertical connectors between them would have zero potential difference ($\Delta V = 0$) and carry no current. Variable-width traces could create voltage differences enabling vertical current flow, but this adds significant manufacturing complexity without clear benefit over optimising the horizontal spacing alone.

2.8 Simulation 6 — Weather Condition Robustness Study

All previous simulations used a fixed ambient condition: $T_{\text{amb}} = 2\,°\text{C}$, $h_{\text{ext}} = 15\,\text{W}\,\text{m}^{-2}\,\text{K}^{-1}$, and $T_{\text{dew}} = 10\,°\text{C}$. Sim 6 tests the final design (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, Chebyshev $p = 1.3$, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$) across five realistic weather scenarios to verify that it performs robustly under a range of real-world conditions.

2.8.1 Weather Scenarios

The five scenarios were selected to cover the full range of conditions a vehicle might encounter in Northwestern Europe [8], from mild autumn fog to extreme winter frost. Each scenario defines a physically consistent set of T_{amb}, T_{dew}, and h_{ext} values — the dew point is not fixed but varies with ambient temperature and relative humidity [1] — as summarised in Table 2.7.

Table 2.7: Weather scenarios tested in Sim 6. Each scenario uses a physically realistic dew point consistent with the ambient humidity conditions.

#	Scenario	T_{amb} (°C)	T_{dew} (°C)	h_{ext} ($\text{W}\,\text{m}^{-2}\,\text{K}^{-1}$)
1	Mild winter	2	10	15
2	Cold winter	-5	0	25
3	Extreme cold	-20	-15	30
4	Cool autumn	10	13	10
5	Freezing rain	-2	0	40

2.8.2 Results

The transient T_{min} for each scenario is shown in Figure 2.11. Each solid curve is paired with a dashed horizontal line at its scenario-specific dew point. Defrost is achieved when the curve crosses its corresponding dashed line.

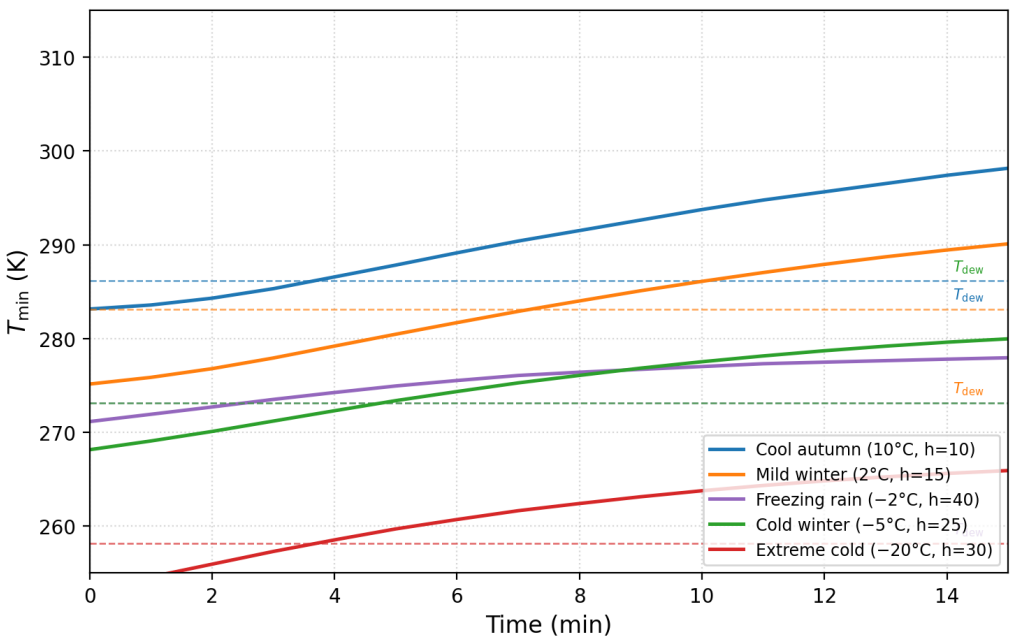


Figure 2.11: Transient minimum surface temperature for all five weather scenarios (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, Chebyshev $p = 1.3$, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$). Each dashed line shows the scenario-specific dew point. All curves cross their dew point within $8\,\text{min}$.

A summary of defrost times, steady-state minimum temperatures, and margins above the dew point is given in Table 2.8.

Table 2.8: Sim 6 results for all five weather scenarios. Margin $= T_{\text{min,SS}} - T_{\text{dew}}$.

#	Scenario	Defrost time	$T_{\text{min,SS}}$ (K)	T_{dew} (K)	Margin (K)
1	Mild winter	7 min	295.0	283.15	$+11.9$
2	Cold winter	4 min 47 s	281.6	273.15	$+8.5$
3	Extreme cold	3 min 41 s	267.0	258.15	$+8.9$
4	Cool autumn	3 min 40 s	307.5	286.15	$+21.4$
5	Freezing rain	2 min 33 s	278.6	273.15	$+5.4$

All five scenarios pass the defrost criterion with positive margin. Key observations are:

- **Faster defrost under harsher convection:** Scenarios with high h_{ext} (freezing rain: 40, extreme cold: 30) defrost in under 4 minutes. The high convective coefficient drives a steeper thermal gradient, which accelerates the initial transient even though the steady-state temperature is lower.
- **Tightest margin in freezing rain (Scenario 5):** With $h_{\text{ext}} = 40\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$ and a high convective heat loss, the steady-state T_{min} is only $5.4\,\mathrm{K}$ above the dew point. This is the worst-case scenario for sustained condensation prevention.
- **Largest margin in cool autumn (Scenario 4):** Low convective loss and mild ambient conditions result in a $21.4\,\mathrm{K}$ margin — more than sufficient.
- **Robustness across $\Delta T_{\text{amb}} = 30\,\mathrm{K}$:** The design passes all scenarios spanning a $30\,\mathrm{K}$ ambient temperature range ($-20\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$ to $10\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$), demonstrating robustness to real-world variability.

Chapter 3

Model Validation

3.1 Mesh Convergence Study

A mesh convergence study was performed to verify that all results are independent of mesh resolution. The study was carried out using a stationary Electric Currents and Heat Transfer solve under the Sim 6 Scenario 1 conditions (mild winter: $T_{\text{amb}} = 2\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$, $h_{\text{ext}} = 15\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$), with the final design (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, Chebyshev $p = 1.3$, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$). Four physics-controlled mesh levels were tested, from Extra Coarse to Extra Fine.

Table 3.1: Mesh convergence results (stationary EC + HT, Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, Chebyshev $p = 1.3$, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$, Scenario 1 conditions).

Mesh level	**Domain elements**	T_{min} **(K)**	ΔT_{min} **vs Extra Fine**
Extra Coarse	185,852	281.607	0.004 K
Coarse	241,089	281.609	0.002 K
Fine	274,402	281.611	$<$0.001 K
Extra Fine	319,050	281.611	—

The minimum surface temperature varies by only $0.004\,\mathrm{K}$ across all four mesh levels, confirming that the solution is fully converged even at Extra Coarse resolution for this geometry. The Fine mesh (274,402 elements) is selected for all simulations as it matches the Extra Fine result to within $0.001\,\mathrm{K}$ while keeping solve times practical.
It should be noted that mesh resolution is more critical for configurations where the result falls close to a threshold. For the Nichrome V material near the dew point:

- **Nichrome V, 18 traces, $12\,\mathrm{V}$:** A coarse mesh predicted a defrost time of 48 minutes, while the Fine mesh reveals that the steady-state $T_{\text{min}} = 283.09\,\mathrm{K}$ remains *below* the dew point — the window never fully defrosts.
- **Nichrome V, 16 traces, $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$:** The coarse mesh predicted "Never", while the Fine mesh gives 59 minutes ($T_{\text{min}} = 283.152\,\mathrm{K}$, barely above the dew point).

These borderline cases confirm that the Fine mesh is necessary for reliable results near the dew point threshold, and justify its use throughout this study.

3.2 Comparison to Literature

The model physics and boundary condition values are validated against published experimental and numerical studies.
The convection coefficients used in this model ($h_{\text{ext}} = 15\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$, $h_{\text{int}} = 7\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$) are compared with experimental measurements by Hożejowska et al. [8], who reported measured h values for automotive glass under various driving conditions. Their results support the order of magnitude used in this study, with exterior values in the range $10\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$ to $25\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$ depending on vehicle speed.
Rühl et al. [4] performed coupled finite element simulations of electrically heated glass panes with resistive lines, validated against infrared thermography and thermocouple measurements. Their modelling approach —

coupling electric currents with heat transfer via Joule heating in a 2D representation — is directly analogous to the physics setup used in this work.
Koshlak et al. [5] measured that 83–85% of the heat generated in electrically heated automotive glass is directed inward (toward the cabin side), which is consistent with the asymmetric convection coefficients used in this model ($h_{\text{int}} < h_{\text{ext}}$, meaning less heat loss to the interior).

3.3 Back-of-Envelope Power and Temperature Estimate

An independent analytical estimate of the steady-state average temperature provides a direct check on the numerical results. The approach is to compute the total Joule heating power from the trace resistance and compare the resulting energy balance temperature with the COMSOL output.
Each trace has electrical resistance:

$$R_{\text{trace}} = \frac{L_{\text{glass}}}{\sigma_{\text{trace}} \cdot w_{\text{trace}} \cdot t_{\text{trace}}} \tag{3.1}$$

For the Sim 1 baseline (silver paste, $\sigma = 2 \times 10^6\,\mathrm{S\,m^{-1}}$):

$$R_{\text{trace}} = \frac{1.5}{2 \times 10^6 \times 1.7 \times 10^{-3} \times 0.11 \times 10^{-3}} = 4.01\,\Omega \tag{3.2}$$

The power per trace is $P_{\text{trace}} = V_{\text{in}}^2/R_{\text{trace}} = 144/4.01 = 35.9\,\mathrm{W}$, and the total power for 12 traces is:

$$P_{\text{total}} = 12 \times 35.9 = 431\,\mathrm{W} \tag{3.3}$$

Note that this physical power is correctly reproduced in the 2D COMSOL model through the σ_{eff} correction (Equation (1.1)): the effective resistance in the model is $R_{\text{model}} = L_{\text{glass}}/(\sigma_{\text{eff}} \cdot w_{\text{trace}} \cdot t_{\text{glass}}) = L_{\text{glass}}/(\sigma_{\text{trace}} \cdot w_{\text{trace}} \cdot t_{\text{trace}}) = R_{\text{trace}}$.
At steady state, the total Joule heating must equal the convective losses from both sides of the glass:

$$P_{\text{total}} = (h_{\text{ext}} + h_{\text{int}}) \cdot A_{\text{glass}} \cdot (T_{\text{avg}} - T_{\text{weighted}}) \tag{3.4}$$

where $A_{\text{glass}} = L_{\text{glass}} \times H_{\text{glass}} = 1.2\,\mathrm{m}^2$ and the convection-weighted ambient temperature is:

$$T_{\text{weighted}} = \frac{h_{\text{ext}} \cdot T_{\text{amb}} + h_{\text{int}} \cdot T_{\text{cabin}}}{h_{\text{ext}} + h_{\text{int}}} = \frac{15 \times 275.15 + 7 \times 293.15}{22} = 280.9\,\mathrm{K} \tag{3.5}$$

Solving for T_{avg}:

$$T_{\text{avg}} = T_{\text{weighted}} + \frac{P_{\text{total}}}{(h_{\text{ext}} + h_{\text{int}}) \cdot A_{\text{glass}}} = 280.9 + \frac{431}{22 \times 1.2} = 280.9 + 16.3 = 297.2\,\mathrm{K} \tag{3.6}$$

The COMSOL surface-average temperature for Sim 1 (12 traces, silver paste, $12\,\mathrm{V}$) is $T_{\text{avg}} = 297.13\,\mathrm{K}$. The back-of-envelope estimate gives $297.2\,\mathrm{K}$ — a deviation of only $0.07\,\mathrm{K}$ ($< 0.03\%$). This excellent agreement confirms that:

- The σ_{eff} correction correctly maps the 3D trace geometry to the 2D model
- The Joule heating and convective boundary conditions are consistently implemented
- The total energy balance of the model is accurate

Table 3.2: Back-of-envelope validation of the average temperature for selected configurations.

Material	n_{traces}	P_{total} (W)	$T_{\text{avg}}^{\text{analytical}}$ (K)	$T_{\text{avg}}^{\text{COMSOL}}$ (K)	**Error**
Silver paste	12	431	297.2	297.13	0.03%
Pd–Ag alloy	14	578	302.8	*— extract from COMSOL*	—

STILL DO: EXTRACT T_{avg} FROM COMSOL FOR Pd–Ag 14-TRACE AND 20-TRACE CONFIGURATIONS TO COMPLETE THE TABLE

3.4 Sensitivity Analysis

The parametric sweeps performed in Sim 2 and Sim 2b serve as a de facto sensitivity analysis, showing how the minimum surface temperature responds to changes in the three main design variables.

Table 3.3: Sensitivity of minimum surface temperature to design parameters (Pd–Ag alloy, baseline: 14 traces, $12\,\mathrm{V}$).

Parameter change	ΔT_{min} **(K)**	**Sensitivity**
n_{traces}: 14 $\rightarrow$ 16 (+2 traces)	+1.40	$0.70\,\mathrm{K}$/trace
V_{in}: 12 $\rightarrow$ $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$ (+$2.5\,\mathrm{V}$)	+1.16	$0.46\,\mathrm{K\,V^{-1}}$
Material: Pd–Ag $\rightarrow$ Nichrome V	-1.49	—

The results confirm that **the number of traces is the most influential parameter**, followed by applied voltage. The choice of trace material has a strong effect through its conductivity: higher conductivity produces more Joule heating per unit length of trace.
The external heat transfer coefficient h_{ext} is also a sensitive parameter (as noted in the literature [8]), since it directly controls the rate of heat loss from the glass. This was systematically addressed in Sim 6 (Section 2.8), which swept h_{ext} alongside T_{amb} and T_{dew} across five realistic weather scenarios, confirming that the final design remains robust across all tested conditions.

Chapter 4

Results and Discussion

4.1 Temperature Distribution

Figure 4.1 shows the steady-state temperature distribution for the recommended design (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $12\,\mathrm{V}$).

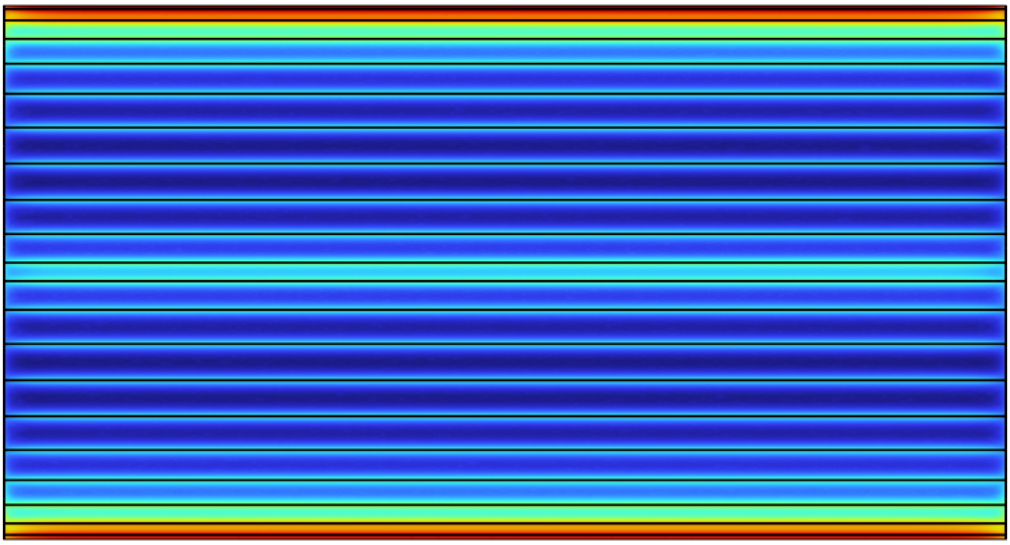


Figure 4.1: Steady-state temperature distribution for the recommended design: Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$. The minimum temperature ($288.2\,\mathrm{K}$) is well above the dew point ($283.15\,\mathrm{K}$).

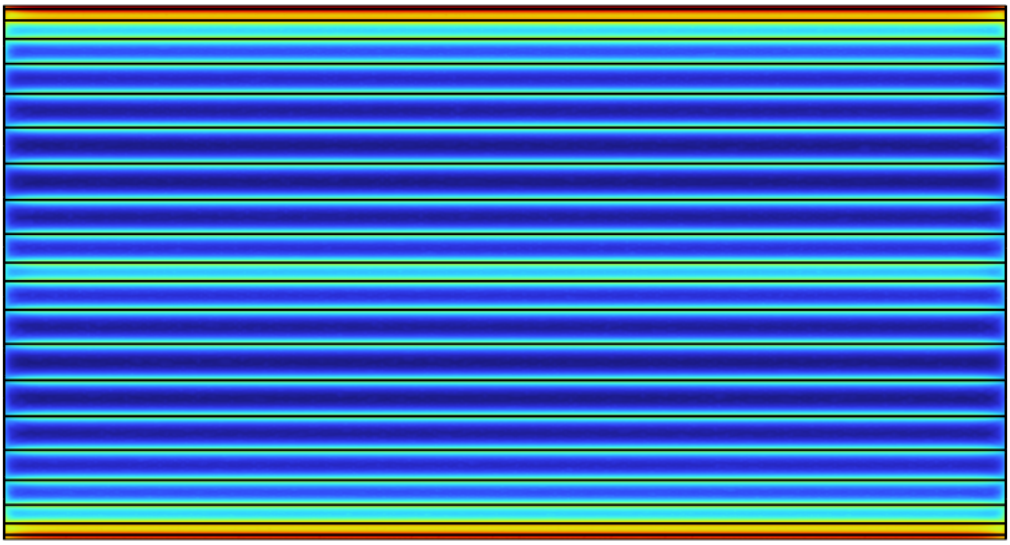


Figure 4.2: Temperature distribution at $t = 12\,\mathrm{min}$ (moment of defrost) for Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$.

4.2 Effect of Trace Material Conductivity

A key finding of this study is the strong dependence of defroster performance on the trace electrical conductivity. The Joule heating power per unit length of trace scales as:

$$P \propto \frac{V_{\text{in}}^2 \cdot \sigma_{\text{eff}}}{L_{\text{trace}}} \tag{4.1}$$

where σ_{eff} is the effective 2D conductivity from Equation (1.1). This explains why:

- Materials with very high conductivity (Silver: 5.75×10^7, Gold: 4.2×10^7 S/m) generate excessive heating, reaching temperatures of 415–465 K at 20 traces — far above safe operating limits.
- The optimal conductivity range for this geometry and voltage is $\sim 10^5$–10^7 S/m, which corresponds to thick-film paste materials such as Pd–Ag alloy and Nichrome V.

Figure 4.3 shows the simulated steady-state T_{min} for all four EduPack materials at $n_{\text{traces}} = 20$, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\mathrm{V}$, plotted against their electrical conductivity on a logarithmic scale. The two viable materials cluster just above the dew point line, while Silver and Gold overheat catastrophically.

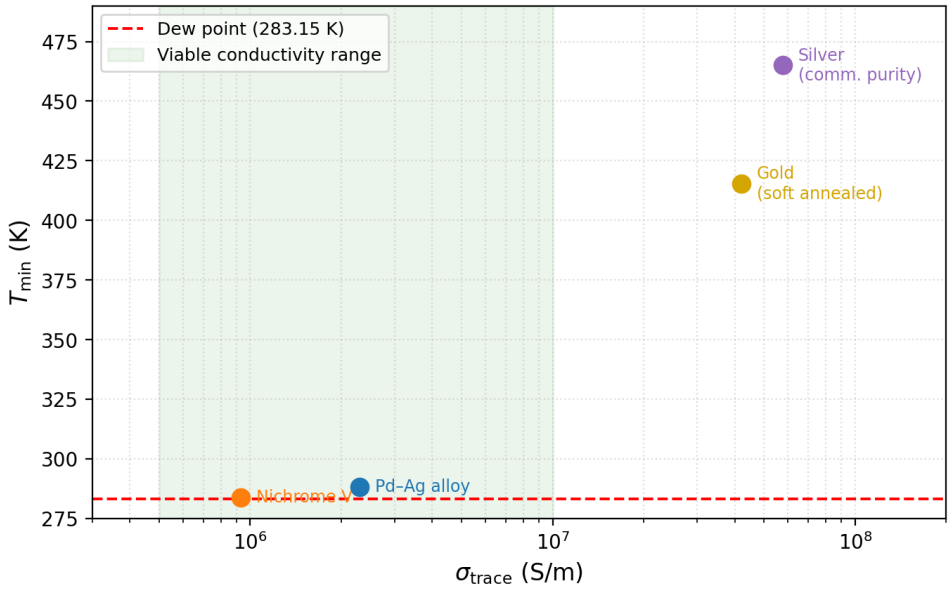


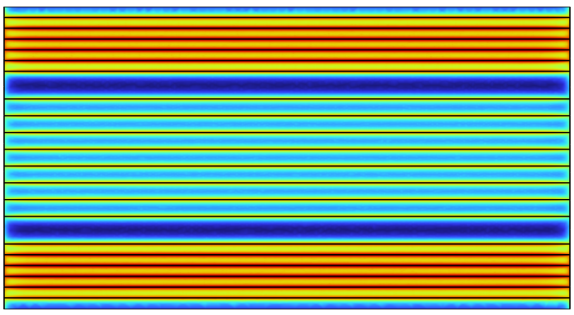
Figure 4.3: Steady-state T_{min} vs. trace electrical conductivity for all four EduPack materials ($n_{\text{traces}} = 20$, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$). The green shaded region indicates the viable conductivity range. Silver and Gold fall far above the safe operating temperature.

4.3 Trace Pattern Optimisation

Two approaches to non-uniform trace spacing were investigated: a discrete zoned layout (Approach A, Sim 4) and a continuous Chebyshev distribution (Approach B, Sim 5). Both use 20 traces of Pd–Ag alloy at $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$ to allow direct comparison with the uniform baseline.

The zoned configuration places 6 traces in the top $200\,\text{mm}$, 8 traces in the middle $400\,\text{mm}$, and 6 traces in the bottom $200\,\text{mm}$. This reduces the edge gap from $38.1\,\text{mm}$ (uniform) to $28.6\,\text{mm}$ while widening the centre gap to $44.4\,\text{mm}$.

The time-dependent simulation shows that this configuration defrosts in $11\,\text{min}$ (vs. $12\,\text{min}$ for uniform) and reaches a steady-state T_{min} of $289.3\,\text{K}$ (vs. $288.2\,\text{K}$). The improvement is modest: $1\,\text{min}$ faster defrost and $1.1\,\text{K}$ higher T_{min}.



TODO (Sebtain): Sim3 uniform 20 traces at defrost moment ($t = 12\,\text{min}$)

Figure 4.4: Temperature distribution at the moment of defrost. (a) Zoned 6/8/6 at $t = 11\,\text{min}$. (b) Uniform baseline at $t = 12\,\text{min}$. Both: Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $12\,\text{V}$.

The Chebyshev approach (Equation (2.1)) is far more effective. With the optimal exponent $p = 1.3$, the edge gaps shrink to $\sim 3\,\text{mm}$ while the widest centre gap reaches $\sim 55\,\text{mm}$. Despite this extreme non-uniformity, the

glass conductivity bridges the centre gap and the overall T_{min} increases substantially because the previously cold edges are now directly heated.

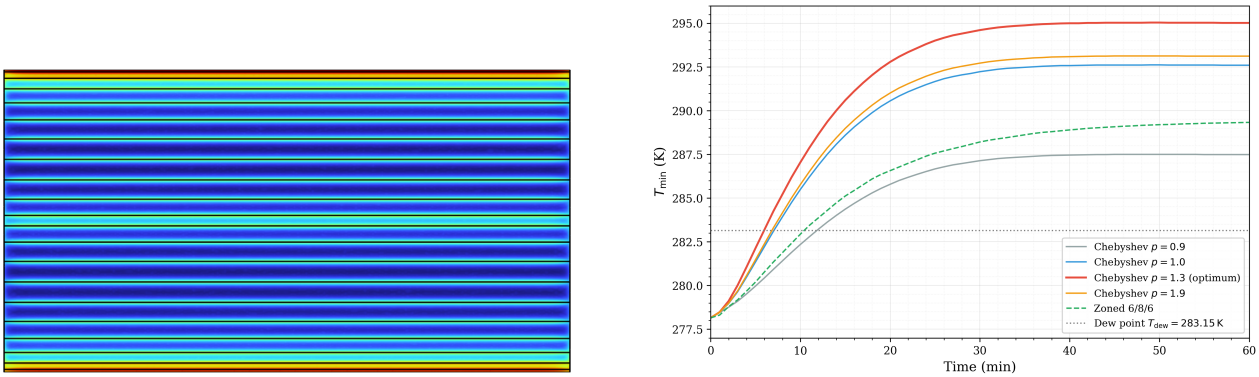


Figure 4.5: Chebyshev spacing results. (a) Temperature distribution at $t = 6\,\text{min}$ for $p = 1.3$. (b) Transient T_{min} evolution for selected p values; the dashed line is the dew point.

Table 4.1 summarises the performance of all trace patterns.

Table 4.1: Comparison of trace spacing approaches (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $V_{\text{in}} = 12\,\text{V}$).

Approach	**Defrost time**	**Steady-state T_{min} (K)**	**Improvement**
Uniform (baseline)	12 min	288.2	—
Zoned A2 (6/8/6)	11 min	289.3	-8% time, $+1.1\,\text{K}$
Chebyshev $p = 1.0$	8 min	292.6	-33% time, $+4.4\,\text{K}$
Chebyshev $p = 1.3$	**6 min**	**295.0**	**-50% time**, $+6.8\,\text{K}$

The Chebyshev $p = 1.3$ spacing halves the defrost time compared to uniform spacing while raising T_{min} by $6.8\,\text{K}$. This is achieved without any change in material, voltage, or number of traces — purely through optimised trace placement. The result demonstrates that **geometry optimisation** using COMSOL's parametric capabilities can be as impactful as material or electrical optimisation.

4.4 Discussion

4.4.1 Strengths

- With Chebyshev spacing ($p = 1.3$), the final design (Pd–Ag alloy, 20 traces, $12\,\text{V}$) achieves a steady-state T_{min} of $295.0\,\text{K}$ — $12\,\text{K}$ above the dew point — and defrosts in only $6\,\text{min}$. With uniform spacing, the same configuration takes $12\,\text{min}$. The improvement comes purely from trace placement, at zero additional cost.
- The thermal stresses are within safe limits (safety factor $\sim 3.1\times$) and the design operates at nominal $12\,\text{V}$ battery voltage, meaning it works even with the engine off.
- The parametric approach (sweeping material, trace count, voltage, and spacing exponent) provides a comprehensive design map that allows easy trade-off analysis for different requirements.
- The multiphysics coupling between Electric Currents, Heat Transfer, and Solid Mechanics captures the essential physics of the defroster operation.
- The mesh convergence study confirms that results are mesh-independent for the recommended configurations.
- The boundary conditions (h_{ext}, h_{int}) are supported by published experimental data [8].
- **The design is robust across real-world weather conditions (Sim 6).** All five scenarios — spanning ambient temperatures from $-20\,°\text{C}$ to $10\,°\text{C}$, external convection coefficients from $10\,\text{W}\,\text{m}^{-2}\,\text{K}^{-1}$ to $40\,\text{W}\,\text{m}^{-2}\,\text{K}^{-1}$, and physically realistic dew points — were defrosted within $8\,\text{min}$, with a minimum steady-state margin of $5.4\,\text{K}$ above the dew point (freezing rain scenario).
- The sequential solve strategy for the stress analysis overcomes the COMSOL 6.2 spatial frame limitation while still capturing the thermal stress state.

4.4.2 Limitations, Future Work, and Broader Implications

- **2D approximation:** The model uses a flat 2D geometry. A real rear window is curved, which affects heat flux distribution and stress concentrations. A 3D simulation with curved glass would be more realistic.
- **Fixed boundary conditions:** The fixed constraint at the glass edges overestimates the peak stress. Modelling the rubber seal as an elastic support would give more realistic stress values.
- **Constant heat transfer coefficients:** In reality, h_{ext} depends on vehicle speed (forced convection) and h_{int} depends on cabin HVAC settings. Sim 6 addressed the former by sweeping h_{ext} from $10\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$ to $40\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$ across five weather scenarios; the effect of varying h_{int} with HVAC state remains as future work.
- **Material property validation:** The EduPack values for Pd–Ag alloy are for bulk material. Screen-printed thick-film pastes may have different effective properties. Experimental validation with a physical prototype is recommended.
- **Contact resistance:** The model does not account for electrical contact resistance between traces and bus bars, which may reduce the effective heating power.

The Chebyshev spacing result has broader implications beyond this specific defroster. The key insight is that **non-uniform spatial distribution of heat sources**, optimised using a single continuous parameter, can be as effective as changing materials or operating conditions. This principle applies to any distributed heating or cooling problem where temperature uniformity is the objective.
In the context of automotive defrosters, the Chebyshev approach could be directly applied to front windshield defrosters (where driver visibility constraints are even more stringent) or to heated mirrors. The p-parameter provides a simple manufacturing specification: a single number that fully defines the trace layout for any given window height and trace count.
Furthermore, the observation that bulk-conductivity materials (Silver, Gold) overheat catastrophically in this geometry has a practical consequence: screen-printed thick-film pastes are not merely a cost-saving alternative to bulk metals — they are *functionally necessary* for the correct thermal behaviour. This finding is consistent with the industrial practice of using Pd–Ag and Ag paste formulations with controlled conductivity [7].
STILL DO: ELEMENT ORDER CONVERGENCE ANALYSIS — comparing linear vs. quadratic elements for the Joule heating/temperature solution to verify that the default element order is sufficient.
STILL DO: ADAPTIVE MESH REFINEMENT ANALYSIS — using COMSOL's adaptive mesh refinement to verify error control near the trace boundaries where temperature gradients are steepest.

Chapter 5

Conclusion

This report presents the design and optimisation of a resistive rear window defroster using coupled multi-physics finite element modelling in COMSOL Multiphysics 6.2. The design was developed iteratively through six simulations addressing thermal performance, material selection, structural integrity, transient response, trace pattern optimisation, and weather condition robustness.
The key findings of this study are:

1. **The number of heating traces is the most influential design parameter.** Increasing the trace count from 12 to 20 raises T_{min} by over $6\,\mathrm{K}$ at $12\,\mathrm{V}$, whereas increasing voltage from 12 to $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$ at 14 traces yields only $1.2\,\mathrm{K}$.

2. **Pd–Ag alloy ($\sigma = 2.3 \times 10^6\,\mathrm{S\,m^{-1}}$) is the optimal trace material.** It reaches the dew point with 14 traces at $12\,\mathrm{V}$, while Nichrome V requires 18–20 traces. Bulk conductivity materials (Silver, Gold) overheat catastrophically and are not viable for this geometry.

3. **Both shortlisted materials pass the stress analysis** with safety factors exceeding $3\times$, confirming that thermal expansion mismatch between the traces and glass does not pose a structural risk.

4. **The recommended design** is:

   - Material: Pd–Ag alloy
   - Number of traces: 20
   - Voltage: $12\,\mathrm{V}$ (nominal battery)
   - Steady-state T_{min}: $288.2\,\mathrm{K}$ ($5\,\mathrm{K}$ above dew point)
   - Defrost time: 12 minutes
   - Stress safety factor: $\sim 3.1\times$

5. **Alternative high-performance design:** Pd–Ag alloy, 22 traces, $14.5\,\mathrm{V}$ — achieves 8-minute defrost time when the engine is running.

6. **The final design is robust across all tested weather conditions (Sim 6).** Five scenarios ranging from mild autumn ($10\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$) to extreme cold ($-20\,^\circ\mathrm{C}$) and freezing rain ($h_{\text{ext}} = 40\,\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}\,K^{-1}}$) were tested, each with a physically realistic dew point [1]. All five scenarios defrost within $8\,\mathrm{min}$ with a minimum steady-state margin of $5.4\,\mathrm{K}$ above the dew point, confirming that the design is not tuned to a single favourable condition.

7. **Chebyshev trace spacing halves the defrost time.** The non-uniform Chebyshev spacing (Equation (2.1)) with exponent $p = 1.3$ reduces the defrost time from $12\,\mathrm{min}$ to $6\,\mathrm{min}$ and raises T_{min} by $6.8\,\mathrm{K}$ — without changing the number of traces, material, or voltage. The discrete zoned approach (6/8/6) provides only a modest $1\,\mathrm{min}$ improvement, confirming that a continuous optimisation is needed. The optimal exponent ($p = 1.3$) was found via a 16-point parametric sweep, exploiting COMSOL's ability to parametrically update the geometry.

8. **Final recommended design:**

   - Material: Pd–Ag alloy ($\sigma = 2.3 \times 10^6\,\mathrm{S\,m^{-1}}$)
   - Number of traces: 20
   - Spacing: Chebyshev with $p = 1.3$

- Voltage: $12\,\mathrm{V}$ (nominal battery)
- Steady-state T_{min}: $295.0\,\mathrm{K}$ ($12\,\mathrm{K}$ above dew point)
- Defrost time: $6\,\mathrm{min}$
- Stress safety factor: $\sim 3.1\times$
- Window obscuration: 4.25% ($< 5\%$ SAE J216 limit)

The simulation methodology — coupling Electric Currents, Heat Transfer, and Solid Mechanics with parametric sweeps over material properties, geometry, and operating conditions — provides a systematic framework for defroster design. The model was validated through mesh convergence, back-of-envelope analytical estimates (agreeing to within 0.03%), and comparison with published experimental data.
The key insight of this study is that **geometry optimisation** (trace placement) can be equally or more impactful than material or electrical optimisation. The Chebyshev spacing approach provides a mathematically principled, single-parameter design specification that can be applied to any rectangular heated-glass application. Future work should extend the model to 3D curved glass, validate against physical prototypes, and investigate the effect of varying interior convection (h_{int}) with different cabin HVAC states.

Bibliography

[1] M. G. Lawrence. The relationship between relative humidity and the dewpoint temperature in moist air. *Bulletin of the American Meteorological Society*, 86(2):225–234, 2005.

[2] J. R. Sayer, M. L. Mefford, and R. Q. Huang. The effect of rear window defroster lines on glare from following headlamps. Technical Report UMTRI-99-12, University of Michigan Transportation Research Institute (UMTRI), 1999. SAE J216 rear window visibility standard.

[3] Granta Design. CES EduPack 2024 — Materials Database, 2024. Granta Design Limited, Cambridge, UK.

[4] S. Rühl, B. Hein, and W. Graf. Coupled finite element simulation of electrically heated glazing. *Glass Structures & Engineering*, 1:237–250, 2016. Coupled EC-HT FEM modelling validated against IR thermography.

[5] H. Koshlak and M. Karpenko. Energy efficiency of electrically heated automotive glass. *Energy Reports*, 11:1224–1234, 2024. 83–85% of heat directed inward.

[6] Robert Bosch GmbH. *Bosch Automotive Handbook*. Wiley, 9th edition, 2014. Automotive electrical systems: nominal 12 V battery voltage, 13.5–14.5 V with alternator charging.

[7] M. Prudenziati and J. Hormadaly. *Printed Films: Materials Science and Applications in Sensors, Electronics and Photonics*. Woodhead Publishing, 2012. Thick-film paste conductivity and defroster trace materials.

[8] S. Hożejowska and M. Piasecka. Numerical solution of axisymmetric inverse heat conduction problem by the trefftz method. *Energies*, 13(3):705, 2020. Heat transfer coefficients for automotive glass under various conditions.